

PM speaking notes for the United Nations General Assembly virtual address

Mr. President, fellow delegates, my friends.

Thank you for the opportunity to address this Assembly. Like many of you, I have spoken in this forum before, but never like this, at a time like this.

The world is in crisis.

And not just because of the last few months. Not just because of COVID-19.

But because of the last few decades. And because of us.

This is our wake-up call, and we cannot ignore it.

Time and time again, history has shown us that the price to pay for turning away, for failing to act, is much too high.

Our parents and grandparents remember all too well what things were like in the 30s and the 40s.

Economies collapsed. Governments – and systems of government – crumbled. Millions died.

That was the world they faced. That was the challenge they had to meet. And this is what they did about it.

Nos parents et grands-parents ont choisi de se relever et de rebâtir.

Ils ont mis sur pied des institutions multilatérales comme les Nations Unies. Ils ont créé des institutions financières internationales comme la Banque mondiale, le FMI et d'autres institutions de Bretton Woods.

Et ils ont jeté les bases d'un ordre international fondé sur des règles grâce auquel nous avons connu une période de prospérité commune sans précédent durant la seconde moitié du XX^e siècle.

We had a system – we had a generation – that learned from crisis and set us on a better path.

In their era, those systems worked. But that was 50, 60, 70 years ago.

Today, all those institutions no longer serve us well enough on what they were designed for – defending multilateralism and international law. Protecting human rights and open markets.

That is what the crisis of COVID-19 has shown, beyond a shadow of a doubt. That things have to change. And not just on the world stage – but at home, too.

Nous n'en faisons pas assez pour les personnes les plus vulnérables – que ce soit les personnes âgées qui meurent dans des établissements de soins de santé, ou les personnes sans-abri pour qui chaque soir est une lutte. Nous n'allons pas assez loin pour éliminer l'injustice systémique, qu'il soit question de racisme envers les Noirs ou les Autochtones, d'homophobie ou de sexisme.

Dans les difficultés de nos citoyens, nous pouvons voir les échecs de nos institutions – de notre monde.

Après que la pandémie a décimé leur économie et leurs services de base, de nombreux pays sont maintenant au bord du gouffre.

C'est ce que j'ai entendu d'un si grand nombre d'entre vous lors de la réunion sur le financement du développement que le Canada a organisée le printemps dernier avec le secrétaire général António Guterres et le premier ministre de la Jamaïque, Andrew Holness.

Nous devons en faire plus pour que les enfants du monde entier soient nourris et qu'ils puissent aller à l'école.

Si nous ne le faisons pas, les conséquences seront désastreuses.

Nous sommes confrontés à une crise humanitaire mondiale.

Et le plus préoccupant dans tout ça, c'est que cette pandémie, et les crises qu'elle a mises en lumière, ne constituent même pas notre plus grande menace.

Right now, our world is facing a climate reckoning.

We are at this point because of our collective inability, over the past decades, to make the tough decisions and sacrifices needed to fight climate change and save future generations.

The pandemic has not changed that. Our shared failures have continued. And our citizens are paying the price.

We need a new way of thinking. On climate, on inequality, on health. Because the way we're doing things just isn't working well enough.

Too often, concerted action is blocked – the needs of our citizens are denied – as a result of gridlock at decision-making bodies.

And why?

Because there are few consequences for countries that ignore international rules. For regimes that think might makes right.

Few consequences for places where opposition figures are being poisoned while cyber tools and disinformation are being used to destabilize democracies.

Few consequences when innocent citizens are arbitrarily detained and fundamental freedoms are repressed. When a plane of civilians is shot from the sky. When women's rights are not treated as human rights. When no one has any rights at all.

We are in deadlock.

The international approach we've relied on since the second half of the 20th century was built on an understanding that countries would work together.

But now those same countries are looking inward, and are divided.

We need to recognize where we are. The system is broken. The world is in crisis.

And things are about to get much worse unless we change.

Right now, we have a chance – not a big chance, but a chance – to shift course. To realize that the only way through this is together.

Putting some people ahead of others does not work. A healthier, cleaner, more equal future cannot be the privilege of a lucky few. It must be the right of us all.

La seule façon d'arranger les choses, la seule façon de bâtir un avenir meilleur pour nos enfants et nos petits-enfants, c'est de travailler ensemble. En nous défendant les uns les autres, quel que soit les lignes dessinées sur des cartes:

Les Rohingyas au Myanmar, les manifestants au Bélarus, le peuple libanais, les citoyens détenus arbitrairement en Chine, les peuples autochtones, au Canada et partout dans le monde.

Une collaboration mondiale réelle et constructive est la seule façon de procéder.

Mais qui sommes-nous pour demander cela?

Le Canada n'est pas un pays qui peut faire bouger bien des choses dans ces grands dossiers internationaux. Comme tant d'autres, nous sommes soumis aux caprices des superpuissances.

Mais en tant que Canadiens, nous savons que nous ne sommes pas seuls.

As Canadians – a trading nation where we trace our origins to every corner of the planet – we know that we are in this together.

And I know other countries – your countries – see this too.

Instead of hunkering down and hoping that we come out the other side ok – let's remember that we're all in this together.

Instead of crossing our fingers and hoping that the big powers will figure this out – let's look at what we can do to make a difference together.

Let's use our shared power not just to get a vaccine, but to get it out to everyone. Let us be inspired by our citizens' call to restore the global economy while we tackle climate change.

In other words, let's not wait for someone else to act.

Let's do it ourselves.

Each one of us, here in these United Nations. Each one of us uniting around a shared future.

Canada has a long history in peacekeeping and we will continue to step up, and continue to move the dial on lasting peace by empowering women.

Canada has always supported the work of agencies like UNICEF, the World Food Programme, and the UNHCR. Not only will we keep supporting these efforts, we'll keep increasing our international assistance budget every year.

There's so much more still to be done.

Aux quatre coins du monde, les enfants portent un masque pour aller à l'école ou ne vont pas à l'école du tout. Des personnes âgées meurent. Des manifestants sont tués. Le niveau des mers monte et les forêts brûlent.

Les gens qui ne pensent qu'à eux-mêmes continuent d'aggraver les inégalités et les conflits.

C'est le moment pour nous, en tant que Nations Unies, d'unir nos forces et de faire ce pour quoi nous avons été créées : assurer la paix et la sécurité. Et éviter les crises globales.

Ces jours-ci nous menons un combat pas comme les autres, mais contre un virus invisible. En même temps, nous luttons contre les conséquences de nos propres actions, à cause desquelles le niveau de carbone dans l'atmosphère est maintenant insoutenable.

Everywhere around the world, people are becoming mindful of this reality. They're refusing to accept inequality. They're refusing to close their eyes to the peril we're facing.

Our citizens will no longer shrug off as someone else's problem a failing status quo.

And that's a good thing. Because there is the path forward.

After a wildfire rips through a forest, life adjusts and begins anew.

After an earthquake hits a city, people work together and rebuild.

As we face these layers of crises, this is what we must do.

We must understand our opportunities and our responsibilities to take real action, together. To protect each other, to support each other.

If we meet this moment, if we rise to this challenge, I know that, like our grandparents did 70 years ago, we will lay the foundations of a better world.